FREE SAMPLE · SPREADSHEET CLEAN-UP

A messy Christmas fair donations sheet, cleaned in one pass

This is a made-up school PTA list of raffle, tombola and cake-stall donations, typed in by several helpers over two weeks. It's a typical shared sheet: the same person entered twice, dates typed a dozen different ways, prices as text, and a filter that can't work because 'Raffle' and 'raffle' count as two different things. Below is the original, then the clean version, then every change we made. The two Excel files are free to download from the service page so you can open them and check our work.

Result: 25 rows in, 2 blank rows removed, 3 duplicates merged, 20 clean rows out. 5 rows are highlighted for a human to check rather than guessed. Donations add up to £281.99, a total the original sheet couldn't give you because some values were text.

Before: the sheet as it arrived (all 25 rows)

#	Name	Class	Date	Donation	Value	Phone	Email	Helping on
2	SMITH, jo	3B	3/10/26	Hamper - wine & choc	£25	07700900101	jo.smith@example.com	tombola
3	Jo Smith	Year 3B	03-10-2026	hamper (wine+choc)	25.00	07700 900 101	JO.SMITH@EXAMPLE.COM	Tombola
4	a. patel	4R	Oct 4	Cake stall - 2 x sponge	10	+44 7700 900102	apatel@example.com	cakes
5	Lee,Sam	rec	2026/10/05	£20 Love2Shop voucher	twenty	7700900103	sam.lee@example	raffle
6								
7	Chloe O'Brien	6	5th Oct	Selection box x6	£18.00	07700-900104	chloe.obrien@example.com	none
8	Mark Davies	2W	05/10/2026	bottle of prosecco	£8.5	07700 900105	mdavies@example.com	Raffle
9	priya shah	1 Red	6/10	Kids craft kit	12	07700900106	priya.shah@example.com	Grotto
10	Tom Hughes	5	06.10.26	Football signed (local club)	?	07700 900107	t.hughes@example.com	bar
11	Hughes, Tom	Y5	6 Oct	signed football		07700900107	t.hughes@example.com	Bar
12	Emma Clarke	3R	7/10/26	Pamper set	£15	07700 900108	emma.clarke@example.com	tombola
13	Ben Okafor	R	10/7/26	Lego set	£30	07700 900109	ben.okafor@example.com	grotto
14	Lucy Bennett	4B	07/10/2026	Wine x2	£16	07700 900110	lucybennett@example.com	raffle
15	Ollie Grant	6W	8/10/26	Christmas jumper (kids 7-8)	£9.99	07700 900111	ollie.grant@example.com	Setup
16	Hannah Moss	2R	08/10/26	Cake stall - brownies	£6	07700 900112	hannah.moss@examplecom	Cakes
17	Daniel Wright	1B	9 October	Garden centre voucher £25	£25	07700 900113	dan.wright@example.com	Raffle
18	Sophie Turner	5R	09/10/2026	Box of Celebrations	£7	07700 900114	sophie.turner@example.com	tombola
19	JAMES KHAN	3W	10/10/26	Bottle of whisky	£22	07700 900115	james.khan@example.com	bar
20	Amy Fisher	4W	10/10/2026	Book bundle (age 5-8)	£12	07700 900116	amy.fisher@example.com	Grotto
21	Rory Doyle	6B	11/10/26	Car wash voucher	£10	07700 900117	rory.doyle@example.com	setup
22								
23	Megan Price	rec	11/10/2026	Cake stall - cupcakes x12	£8	07700 900118	megan.price@example.com	cakes
24	Kofi Mensah	2B	12/10/26	Toy car set	£14	07700 900119	kofi.mensah@example.com	Tombola
25	Grace Walker	1W	12-10-26	Candle & reed diffuser	£13.50	07700 900120	grace.walker@example.com	raffle
26	megan price	Reception	11/10/26	cupcakes (12)	8	07700900118	megan.price@example.com	Cakes

After: one row per donation, sorted, totals that work

Amber rows need a quick human check. We tell you why in the last column instead of quietly making something up. Dates are real dates (so they sort), values are numbers in £, and the header row is frozen with filters switched on.

Name	Class	Date given	Donation	Value (£)	Phone	Email	Helping on	Check
Jo Smith	Year 3B	03/10/2026	Hamper - wine & choc	£25.00	07700 900101	jo.smith@example.com	Tombola	
A. Patel	Year 4R	04/10/2026	Cake stall - 2 x sponge	£10.00	07700 900102	apatel@example.com	Cake stall	
Chloe O'Brien	Year 6 (class?)	05/10/2026	Selection box x6	£18.00	07700 900104	chloe.obrien@example.com	Not helping	Class letter missing
Mark Davies	Year 2W	05/10/2026	Bottle of prosecco	£8.50	07700 900105	mdavies@example.com	Raffle	
Sam Lee	Reception	05/10/2026	£20 Love2Shop voucher	£20.00	07700 900103	sam.lee@example	Raffle	Value written as a word; read as £20; Email looks incomplete; check before sending a thank-you
Priya Shah	Year 1R	06/10/2026	Kids craft kit	£12.00	07700 900106	priya.shah@example.com	Grotto	
Tom Hughes	Year 5 (class?)	06/10/2026	Football signed (local club)		07700 900107	t.hughes@example.com	Bar	No value given; Class letter missing
Ben Okafor	Reception	07/10/2026	Lego set	£30.00	07700 900109	ben.okafor@example.com	Grotto	Written month-first (US style); read as 7 Oct, please confirm
Emma Clarke	Year 3R	07/10/2026	Pamper set	£15.00	07700 900108	emma.clarke@example.com	Tombola	
Lucy Bennett	Year 4B	07/10/2026	Wine x2	£16.00	07700 900110	lucybennett@example.com	Raffle	
Hannah Moss	Year 2R	08/10/2026	Cake stall - brownies	£6.00	07700 900112	hannah.moss@examplecom	Cake stall	Email looks incomplete; check before sending a thank-you
Ollie Grant	Year 6W	08/10/2026	Christmas jumper (kids 7-8)	£9.99	07700 900111	ollie.grant@example.com	Set-up	
Daniel Wright	Year 1B	09/10/2026	Garden centre voucher £25	£25.00	07700 900113	dan.wright@example.com	Raffle	
Sophie Turner	Year 5R	09/10/2026	Box of Celebrations	£7.00	07700 900114	sophie.turner@example.com	Tombola	
Amy Fisher	Year 4W	10/10/2026	Book bundle (age 5-8)	£12.00	07700 900116	amy.fisher@example.com	Grotto	
James Khan	Year 3W	10/10/2026	Bottle of whisky	£22.00	07700 900115	james.khan@example.com	Bar	
Megan Price	Reception	11/10/2026	Cake stall - cupcakes x12	£8.00	07700 900118	megan.price@example.com	Cake stall	
Rory Doyle	Year 6B	11/10/2026	Car wash voucher	£10.00	07700 900117	rory.doyle@example.com	Set-up	
Grace Walker	Year 1W	12/10/2026	Candle & reed diffuser	£13.50	07700 900120	grace.walker@example.com	Raffle	
Kofi Mensah	Year 2B	12/10/2026	Toy car set	£14.00	07700 900119	kofi.mensah@example.com	Tombola	

Every change we made

This change log is the third tab of the clean file. You can see exactly what moved, so nothing disappears without a reason.

Where	What we changed
Whole sheet	All names: 'Surname, First' flipped and capitalised (e.g. 'SMITH, jo' to 'Jo Smith')
Whole sheet	Classes: 'rec', 'R', 'Reception' to 'Reception'; '3B', 'Y5', 'Year 3B' to 'Year 3B' style
Whole sheet	Dates: typed in many different styles ('3/10/26', '03-10-2026', 'Oct 4', '2026/10/05', '5th Oct', '06.10.26') turned into real dates (DD/MM/YYYY) you can sort
Whole sheet	Values: '£8.5', '25.00', '£25' turned into numbers in £ so totals add up
Whole sheet	Phones: '+44 7700…', '7700…', dashes and spaces all to '07700 900123' style
Whole sheet	Emails: lower-cased, trailing spaces removed
Whole sheet	Helping on: 13 different spellings reduced to 7 roles, so the filter works
Whole sheet	Sorted by date, header frozen, filters switched on
Row 6	Blank row removed
Row 22	Blank row removed
Row 3	Duplicate of row 2 (Jo Smith, Hamper - wine & choc) merged
Row 11	Duplicate of row 10 (Tom Hughes, Football signed (local club)) merged
Row 26	Duplicate of row 23 (Megan Price, Cake stall - cupcakes x12) merged

Summary tab (in the Excel file): helpers and donation value by stall

Helping on	Helpers	Donations valued (£)
Bar	2	£22.00
Cake stall	3	£24.00
Grotto	3	£54.00
Not helping	0	£18.00
Raffle	5	£83.00
Set-up	2	£19.99
Tombola	4	£61.00
Total	19	£281.99

What we didn't do

We didn't guess the missing football value, the missing class letters, or whether '10/7/26' means 7 October. We didn't fix the two broken email addresses by inventing the missing part. Those rows are amber so someone who knows the family can check in a minute. On a paid job we work the same way: if we can't be sure, we flag it.

Before you send us a spreadsheet: 8-point checklist

	Check
☐	Send the original file, not a copy someone has already half-fixed.
☐	Tell us what the finished sheet is for (thank-you emails, a raffle prize list, a mailing list, a stock count).
☐	Name the columns you must keep, and any you can drop.
☐	Say how you want dates, names and money shown, or leave it to UK defaults (DD/MM/YYYY, First Surname, £0.00).
☐	If two rows might be the same person, tell us what makes them the same (phone, email, account number).
☐	Don't send passwords, full card numbers or bank log-ins. We never need them.
☐	PDF statements and scans are fine. Text PDFs usually convert cleanly; scans and photos are read and checked by hand.
☐	Say if you'd rather we didn't use AI tools. We'll do it without them.

Want yours done?

Small job £15: up to 500 rows or about 5 PDF pages, back in 2 working days, one round of changes. Pay £15 by Stripe.

Large job £60: up to 10,000 rows or 60 PDF pages, merged from several files if needed, summary tab included, back in 3 working days. Pay £60 by Stripe.

Bigger or monthly? Email tchworks.shop@agentmail.to for a fixed quote before we start.

Details, FAQs and these sample files: tchworks.co.uk/services/spreadsheet-clean-up

Do it yourself instead? Our free open-source script turns text PDFs into CSV or Excel on your own computer: github.com/wilsonryan-hue/pdf-tables-to-csv

Written with AI assistance and checked by the TCH Works team. The clean-up in this pack was done by a short Python script, then checked row by row. Every name, phone number (Ofcom drama range 07700 900xxx) and email (example.com) is fictional.